fleeting experiences, memories and expectations must be disciplined and focused upon a single point. Taxing asceticism (*tapas*), *mantra*-recitation, the study of scriptures about liberation (*svadhyaya*), and the direction of the mind to *Ishvara* all lead to contemplation (*samadhi-bhavana*) and the attenuation of the defects (*klesha*) of ignorance, egoism, desires, dislikes and obsessive attachments. Ignorance (*avidya*) – the perception of the impermanent as permanent, the impure as the pure, pain as pleasure and non-self as self – is the basic problem.

The eight stages of the physical, moral and mental discipline that form classical *Yoga* are:

- Self-restraint (*Yama*): non-violence, honesty in thought, word and deed, sexual restraint and lack of greed.
- Discipline (*Niyama*): interiorisation, tranquillity, asceticism, mantra recitation, the study of texts on liberation, and attention to God.
- Physical postures (*Asana*): exercising control over the psychosomatic complex.
- Breath-control (*Pranayama*): regulation and reduction of the processes of inhalation and exhalation that increase psychophysical control.
- Withdrawal of the senses from their objects (*Pratyahara*) and direction of attention to the inner self.
- Attention (*Dharana*): fixing the mind on a single point (that is, an object of meditation).
- Meditation (*Dhyana*): the uninterrupted continuity of awareness about the object of meditation.
- Profound contemplative introversion (*Samadhi*).

The state of liberation from rebirth is understood as one of wholeness and isolation (*kaivalya*) where